

use IrfanView and think they're doing something extremely out of the ordinary and would stake their life on the application being the best image viewer in the world.

**Fear of not knowing better** - If you didn't know for example that an Archos or Cowon PMP can outdo an iPod, you'd still say your iPod rocks because you don't want to admit that you didn't know of alternatives. The same way a Winamp fanboy will not admit to liking Foobar because he probably doesn't know the various features of Foobar, and it's easier to dismiss it.

**Endowment Effect** - This basically means that once you own something (of follow some practice) it becomes a little bit more valuable. What you must understand is that it is more valuable to only you. Everyone else in the world may not necessarily share your love for Jigglypuff from Pokemon.

**Justification of choice** - It might be the hardcore research you've conducted. Or just the amount of hard cash you've shelled out, every person wants to justify their choice.

**Investment** - An investment can be in terms of both time and money. Once you've spent some time with a particular thing you have an investment which makes you want to stick to it longer. Besides, no one wants to admit their car's a lemon right.

## Case Study

Lets now come back to the case that sparked off this journey into the investigation of Fanboyism. We began with talking about Winamp and Windows Media Player. Several arguments were thrown about, many based in fact, many based in perception, and many were just misinformation. The Winamp fanboy in the team didn't really know that the most recent version of WMP allowed nearly all of the features that he was throwing at his opponent as defence. When the arguments were stricken off one by one the last thing he had to say (like any other fanboy) was "WMP just sucks man". Now at Digit we don't take lightly to biases, even when so minuscule as a media player. So in our typical Digit determination to unravel the truth, we ran a small empirical feature comparison. And what do you know! Both players aren't drastically better or worse. Now there are

## Famous fan boy wars

### PC vs Mac

A battle nearly as age old as desktop computing. Through the ages we've witnessed smear campaigns from both sides. Whether its FUD (Fear, Uncertainty, Doubt) tactics or through those awesomely funny ad campaigns, we've enjoyed every moment. But off late haven't you noticed the Mac guy has become this snarky hipster whom you just want to slap. "God I hate that guy" is the only thing that comes to mind.

### Firefox v/s well... the world!

Most Firefox users would cringe at the thought of insane load times, but would quickly point out security, extension support, grease monkey scripts in defence of their favourite browser.

### Unreal Tournament v/s Quake III

Faster gameplay was what fanboys screamed in favour of Q3, and cool weapons for UT. Although this debate has died out in the rest of the world, we being a little old school (read:fuddydiddies) still have occasional dissing matches. Sambhav was recently heard saying "UT is much more fun to play dude, Q3 is..." and then he proceeded to make a gesture that we cannot describe in print.

### Android v/s iOS

One of the newly emerging factions across the world. The Android army let out squeals of joy when the iPhone 4 antenna issue happened. Apple fanboys on the other hand at least for now heavily outnumber them. iPhone users feel it's Ok to own any phone as long as it's an iPhone.

### Facebook v/s Twitter

Like the above example, this one is also a relatively new war. And the flame war is catching on in India too. After setting their sights on the Orkutiyas (as they like to call the remaining stragglers of the orkut era) the so called Twitterati now spend a considerable amount of time dissing people who predominantly use Facebook. Funny thing is that all of them still maintain a Facebook profile.

### PS3 vs. Xbox 360

The comment section for any online review for a Halo or Call of Duty invariably turns into the favourite flame war of the day. PS3s are usually called cheap Blu-ray players while Microsoft's operating system disasters are quoted to beleaguer the Xbox gang.

### Penguins v/s well again, the world

No one really gives a \$!-!% about you. No no we're kidding of course. There's an entire article dedicated to this subject elsewhere in the magazine.

nerds on Audiophile forums who claim to discern audio quality differences but we'll keep repudiation of such claims to another rant. So why did this now disillusioned member of the team so ferociously defend Winamp? An interesting and often quoted experiment concerning Coke and Pepsi comes to mind. Now pay close attention to this next bit boys and girls. The Baylor college of Medicine gave subjects unmarked glasses of Cola. All through the experiment the subjects were hooked on to a functional magnetic resonance imaging (fMRI) - that's brain scanner to the uninitiated - which showed that many of them liked Pepsi. Next the researchers told them that they'd

been drinking Pepsi. Now an interesting phenomenon was noticed. The MRI scans of a fraction of subjects who were Coke fanboys, showed their brains trying desperately to mitigate the pleasure centers. What researchers concluded was that huge neural buildups in their brain genuinely prevented them from admitting their preference for Pepsi, or rather that they altered their wiring to suit a bias. So the next time you feel a bout of involuntary verbal diarrhoea rising up to defend your favourite 'something', remember your rigid neural networks, remember your biases, remember Spock's cold logic and then comment. Our last word - to each his own. 